



Colorado State Committee Meeting – August 27, 2026

Agenda

Final

Regular Session

Meeting Place:

Colorado State Office
Denver Federal Center
Lakewood, CO 80225

OR

Virtual Meeting via Teams

August 27 STC Meeting

Conference line: 1 970-812-0909 - Phone conference ID: 499 641 44#

Meeting Time:

3:30 PM (All times are approximate)

Guests: None Scheduled

1. Call to Order

2. Approve Regular Session Minutes (Action Item)

Presented by: Cindy Vukasin, Farm Program Chief

- a. July 23, 2026

3. State Executive Director Report (10 min)

4. District Director Report (20 min)

- a. District 1: Scott Brase
- b. District 2: Jon Weishaar (Oral report)
- c. District 3: Woody Woods
- d. District 4: Sam Montoya

5. Senior Leadership Reports (5 min)

- a. Acting Farm Loan Chief: Kim Lacy
- b. Farm Program Chief: Cindy Vukasin
- c. Farm Program Chief: Corey Pelton
- d. Deputy State Executive Director: Jon Weishaar

6. Noninsured Crop Disaster Assistance Program (NAP)

Presented by: Janae Rader, Farm Program Specialist

- a. Delegation: Designate DD as STC Representative (Action Item) (5 min) (Page 19)

7. Emergency Forest Restoration Program (EFRP)

Presented by: Hunter A. Cleveland, Agricultural Program Specialist

- a. CSFS EFRP Implementation Recommendation (**Action Item**) (15 min) **(Page 23)**

8. Agricultural Risk Coverage/Price Loss Coverage Program (ARC/PLC)

Presented by: Doug Andresen, Farm Program Specialist

- a. 2025 DAFP Yield Solicitation (**Action item**) (15 min) **(Page 51)**

9. State Committee Field Discussion update

10. Adjourn Regular Session (Action Item**)**

Regular Session

Leadership Reports

State Executive Director Update
Jerry Sonnenberg
August 27, 2026

STAFFING:

We have received our new hiring ceilings which have been increased to 93 on the CO side and 33 on the GS accounts. We currently stand at 80 in the county offices and 32 federal employees.

Since our last meeting, we hired Dylan Bell as the new CED in Weld County and also made an offer to Adrian Walck to be the CED in Mesa County. After considering the offer, she declined and then resigned. This was an unfortunate situation which had extenuating circumstances that I am happy to share if asked.

Ultimately, we offered the Mesa/Garfield CED to Sam Hyslop and he has accepted. His onboarding date is August 24.

We are currently advertising for a CED in both Sedgwick and Phillips Counties. We are also advertising for an AO so that Jon, our DSED, will be able focus on DSED and continuing as the DD in District Two.

Our next hire is to fill the vacant CED in Rio Grande County. Sonya Yund has been handling those duties as well as the Alamosa CED duties.

With the new ceiling levels, we will aggressively hire staff for the county offices.

Our priorities are to fill all the CED positions first. We then will start filling to our ceiling with PA's. Our current priority has been Mesa/Garfield, Baca, and Weld. With the new ceilings, I will work with our DD's to prioritize our next hires.

BUDGET:

On the GS side, we have \$43,854.62 left in travel. I have allocated \$22,500 for Farm Loans to do site visits and training. I have budgeted \$5,000 for STC meeting in August and we will have an in person training September 22-24. I have budgeted \$1,000 a month for DD travel for Sam. I have added \$1,000 for DD travel to Jon's old district in which Jon and I continue to try and cover. Even though we have used some of this travel, I continue to have allocated 10 nights at \$250 per night or \$2,500 for Chiefs and Specialists to travel. I will travel as needed but limited.

On the CO side, we have \$37,112.41 left for travel. COC meetings cost and average of \$6,000 per month or \$23,360 for the last four months. However, our entire travel expenditures over the first 8 months only averages \$2,244 a month. That is less than half of what was anticipated. I still haven't figured out why that number doesn't correlate with the budget but I know a lot of these meetings get cancelled. I had allocated funds for jump teams to send people to other parts of the state that may need help. However, it has become more transparent that if I pull people away

from their current offices to help in other offices, I am just moving the work deficiency. We are working to cover as much as we can with current nearby staff.

We are bringing in all the employees from the county offices for an in-person training. That meeting will be the week of September 14 and is being funded by DC so we will not use this budget item as we had planned. With everyone coming in for an in-person training, we are dropping the regional meetings, at least for this budget cycle.

Jon and I have been authorizing Overtime when a specific need arises and there is a way to track the effectiveness of the Overtime. We anticipate OT will continue to be requested by the counties and the DD's and STO will continue to authorize that OT so that we can reduce the backlog.

WELD COUNTY OFFICE:

It appears we may be somewhat back to a normal internet so the Weld County staff is back into the temporary office and doing well.

They awarded the new lease and 8750 W 20th St, Greeley, CO will be our long-term lease when it is ready. It apparently takes government five months to figure out where cubicles and a limited number of office walls need to be located. It then takes another five months to build them. We anticipate being able to move into the new office in June of 2027.

Unfortunately, this is being handled by the Business Office in DC and they have struggled at getting things done in a timely manner. There is a huge push by a number of us SED's to allow us to manage our own state offices and leases as well as some other functions now being handled by the business center.

POLICY ISSUES:

I have included the documents for a discussion during our Executive Session regarding the declining CEY's through out the state.

SED THOUGHTS:

In the last month, I have traveled some but have not accomplished what I had intended with that travel.

District 1 Update
Scott Brase
August 27, 2026

Program Updates:

- **NAP-** Offices are working through Prevented Planting loss claims as well as numerous crop loss claims due to drought, hail, high heat, and wind. Produce crops have been hit hard with multiple hail events.
- **CRP-** Offices are working to notify producers of the status of the Grassland CRP offers. They will continue working with the producers and NRCS to develop Conservation Plans for accepted offers.
- **LFP-** The Livestock Forage Program is active in all counties in the district. Offices are currently taking and processing applications.
- **ELAP-** Several Counties are working on Honeybee losses from Colony Collapse Disorder as well as honeybee losses due to wildfires. There has been activity for the feed, water, and livestock transportation due to drought and fire.
- **ECP and EFRP-** The Baca County and Pueblo County offices are actively working with producers to determine needs for cleanup and rebuilding fencing, watering facilities, and trees due to the wildfires and flooding. The Pueblo office has had an influx of new producers seeking assistance which has caused a heavy load as most of them have no eligibility documentation or farm information in our systems yet.

Aspen Acres Fire- The fire is still active at the time of this report it is 72% contained and has burned 1025,004 acres. The Pueblo/Fremont office has conducted 2 separate outreach meetings to provide FSA program information to any affected producers. There has been a very large response from producers seeking all assistance available.

Heavy rains in the area have also caused multiple flooding events which are adding to the damage.

- **LIP-** There have been livestock losses due to the wildfires and high temperatures that the area has been experiencing. Producers are gathering the information needed to apply.
- **Payment Eligibility-** Counties are working to notify entities regarding the Qualified Pass Through Entities to obtain information and make determinations on which entities qualify. This has caused a large workload with a short turnaround.

Staffing Updates:

Mary Rhoades, Farm Loan Officer in Lamar has retired.

Temporary PAs have been hired in the Trinidad office and the Cheyenne Wells office.

Critical PA vacancies remain in the Prowers and Baca County offices.

Farm Loan

New loan application activity remains low due to the timing of year as well as uncertainty in the Ag economy. Both offices remain busy with servicing activities for producers who are experiencing hardships due to increases in expenses and decreases in income and increased production costs.

Crop Conditions, Livestock, and Weather:

Weather conditions continue to be hot, windy, and predominately dry over most of the district. There have been some good moisture events that brought widespread beneficial precipitation to most of the area, with amounts ranging from half of an inch to over two inches in some areas.

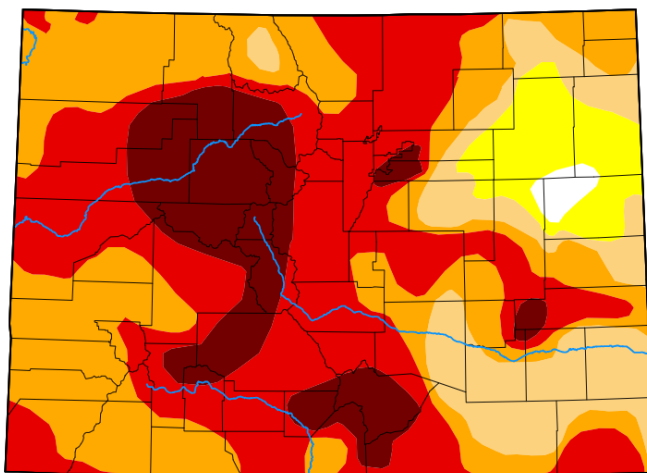
There have been widespread crop failures due to drought and lack of irrigation water. Surface water irrigation is relying on rain/flood events to provide enough river flow to provide short opportunities to run water. Moisture events in many areas have been accompanied by wind and hail, which has done substantial damage to crops. Forage crops continue to show stress and reduced yields.

Livestock is doing well overall. Native grass pasture conditions continue to vary greatly based on precipitation received.

Hay supplies remain very tight as many livestock producers are currently feeding as well as trying to purchase their winter feed needs. There have been continued reports of heavier than normal culling as a result of drought affected pastures and reduced feed supply as well as early weaning. Some livestock producers are looking at partial herd liquidations.

Drought conditions have improved slightly in a few areas and have worsened in others. The entire district remains in drought conditions ranging from D1 to D4.

August 13, 2026



Intensity

- None
- D0 (Abnormally Dry)
- D1 (Moderate Drought)
- D2 (Severe Drought)
- D3 (Extreme Drought)
- D4 (Exceptional Drought)
- No Data

Authors

United States and Puerto Rico Author(s):

[Richard Tinker](#), NOAA/NWS/NCEP/CPC

Pacific Islands and Virgin Islands Author(s):

[Daniel Whitesel](#), National Drought Mitigation Center

**District 3 Update
Woody Woods
August 27, 2026**

Program Updates:

- **CRP**– NRCS is returning plans for General, Continuous, and Grasslands CRP. No problems are anticipated at this time.
- **ARCPLC** – Producers continue to ask about base reallocation.
- **Acreage Reporting** – Kit Carson finished their register in 2 weeks while Weld finished in 3 weeks.
- **Prevent Plant** – A large number of farms reported failed acres and prevent plant acres in District 3.

County	Farms w/Failed Acres	Farms w/Prevent Plant Acres	Fully Reported Farms
Kit Carson	222	33	1530
Logan	55	59	1504
Morgan	64	196	867
Phillips	19	1	900
Sedgwick	26	45	647
Washington	410	20	1623
Weld	185	743	2557
Yuma	114	29	1616

- **SDRP** – Signup continues!
- **LFP** – All counties are accepting LFP applications.
- **ELAP** – Applications are trickling in for Feed Transportation.
- **LIP** - Several inquiries were received from livestock producers who lost animals due to heat. At this time, no Notices of Loss have been filed.
- **Farm Loan** – Workload continues to be high but the Sterling office has made great progress in processing applications and servicing.
- **PL** - Counties have started on updating CCC-902's for the Qualified Pass-Through Entities. This is a big task and concern exists over how quickly it can be accomplished.
- **ASCF** – Most applications have been approved and paid. State payments follow.

County, State	Program Payment Signed Amount	% Disbursed from Amount sent to NPS	Program Payment Signed Count	% of Payables Disbursed
Adams, CO	\$10,215	100%	2	100%
Alamosa, CO	\$1,071,900	79%	15	83%
Boulder, CO	\$74,226	100%	5	100%
Conejos, CO	\$230,828	89%	3	60%
Costilla, CO	\$70,058	100%	1	100%
Crowley, CO	\$10,030	100%	2	100%
Delta, CO	\$658,313	100%	38	100%
Dolores, CO	\$87,641	100%	33	100%
Elbert, CO	\$4,121	100%	1	100%
Fremont, CO	\$4,800	100%	5	100%
Garfield, CO	\$1,079	100%	2	100%
Kit Carson, CO	\$29,325	100%	16	100%
La Plata, CO	\$9,281	100%	5	100%
Larimer, CO	\$139,336	100%	9	100%
Logan, CO	\$46,106	100%	5	100%
Mesa, CO	\$783,917	99%	33	97%
Montezuma, CO	\$51,179	100%	20	100%
Montrose, CO	\$348,779	100%	31	97%
Morgan, CO	\$7,867	47%	3	75%
Otero, CO	\$455,298	100%	32	100%
Phillips, CO	\$94,514	100%	32	100%
Pitkin, CO	\$941	100%	2	100%
Pueblo, CO	\$710,552	100%	42	100%
Rio Grande, CO	\$3,351,997	100%	44	100%
Saguache, CO	\$1,784,607	100%	26	100%
Sedgwick, CO	\$42,966	100%	10	100%
Washington, CO	\$60,979	100%	6	100%
Yuma, CO	\$751,611	88%	67	85%
Total as 8/17/26	\$10,892,465			

Staffing Updates:

- The Weld COC selected Dylan Bell as CED.
- CED announcements close for Phillips and Sedgwick August 28, 2026
- The SDRP temps continue to contribute and be critical to serving the producers. It was appreciated that they were extended to 12/31/26.

Crop Conditions, Livestock, and Weather:

Spring crop conditions vary greatly across the district. In some areas, NI corn, millet and feed look almost normal while other areas might be lucky to recoup harvesting expenses. Livestock continues to sell very well but hay prices have also continued to increase. The last Hay Auction from the Brush Livestock Exchange showed 2nd cutting alfalfa in small square bales selling for \$625.00/ton.

HAY MARKET REPORT			
August 15, 2026	3,600 Bales	96 CONSIGNERS	77 Buyers
Alfalfa - 2nd cutting	48# SM SQ	\$15.00 a bale/	\$625.00 /a ton
Alfalfa - 3rd Cutting	736# 3X3	\$180.00 a bale/	\$489.20 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd cutting	47# SM SQ	\$11.00 a bale/	\$468.00 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd cutting	41# SM SQ	\$9.50 a bale/	\$463.40 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd cutting	1138# 3X4	\$250.00 a bale/	\$439.40 /a ton
Alfalfa - 3rd cutting	61# SM SQ	\$11.50 a bale/	\$377.00 /a ton
Alfalfa - 3rd cutting	720# 3X3	\$130.00 a bale/	\$361.20 /a ton
Alfalfa - 1st Cutting	1180# 3X4	\$205.00 a bale/	\$347.40 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd Cutting	787# 3X3	\$135.00 a bale/	\$343.00 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd Cutting	1267# 3X4	\$215.00 a bale/	\$339.40 /a ton
Alfalfa - 1st Cutting	1154# 3X4	\$195.00 a bale/	\$338.00 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd Cutting	1203# 3X4	\$195.00 a bale/	\$324.20 /a ton
Alfalfa - 1st Cutting	1142# 3X4	\$185.00 a bale/	\$324.00 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd Cutting	1211# 3X4	\$195.00 a bale/	\$322.00 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd Cutting	1766# 3X4	\$280.00 a bale/	\$317.20 /a ton
Alfalfa - 1st Cutting	1847# ROUND	\$290.00 a bale/	\$314.00 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd Cutting	1763# 4X4	\$270.00 a bale/	\$306.20 /a ton
Alfalfa - 2nd Cutting	1278# 3X4	\$195.00 a bale/	\$305.20 /a ton
Grass	694# 3X3	\$160.00 a bale/	\$461.00 /a ton
Grass	469# 3X3	\$85.00 a bale/	\$362.40 /a ton
Grass	813# 3X3	\$145.00 a bale/	\$356.80 /a ton
Grass	649# 3X3	\$115.00 a bale/	\$354.40 /a ton
Grass	658# 3X3	\$115.00 a bale/	\$349.60 /a ton
Grass	632# 3X3	\$110.00 a bale/	\$348.20 /a ton
Grass	674# 3X3	\$105.00 a bale/	\$311.60 /a ton
Grass	698# 3X3	\$105.00 a bale/	\$300.80 /a ton
Grass	1321# ROUND	\$195.00 a bale/	\$295.20 /a ton
Grass	1289# ROUND	\$185.00 a bale/	\$287.00 /a ton
Grass	674# 3X3	\$95.00 a bale/	\$281.80 /a ton
Grass	1298# ROUND	\$180.00 a bale/	\$277.40 /a ton
Grass	690# 3X3	\$95.00 a bale/	\$275.40 /a ton
Mix	613# 3X3	\$165.00 a bale/	\$538.40 /a ton
Mix	539# 3X3	\$140.00 a bale/	\$519.40 /a ton
Mix	1301# 3X4	\$250.00 a bale/	\$384.40 /a ton
Mix	1254# 3X4	\$220.00 a bale/	\$350.80 /a ton
Mix	1835# 4X4	\$260.00 a bale/	\$283.40 /a ton
Sorghum	1757# 4X4	\$175.00 a bale/	\$199.20 /a ton
Sorghum	1494# 4X4	\$145.00 a bale/	\$194.20 /a ton
Sorghum	1409# 4X4	\$135.00 a bale/	\$191.60 /a ton
Sorghum	1471# 4X4	\$140.00 a bale/	\$190.40 /a ton
Sorghum	1528# 4X4	\$145.00 a bale/	\$189.80 /a ton

August 15, 2026	3,600 Bales	96 CONSIGNERS	77 Buyers
Sorghum	1526# 4X4	\$140.00 a bale/	\$183.40 /a ton
Sorghum	1591# 4X4	\$145.00 a bale/	\$182.20 /a ton
Sorghum	1577# 4X4	\$140.00 a bale/	\$177.60 /a ton
Sorghum	1538# 4X4	\$135.00 a bale/	\$175.60 /a ton
Millet	1580# 4X4	\$180.00 a bale/	\$227.80 /a ton
Millet	1204# 3X4	\$135.00 a bale/	\$224.20 /a ton
Millet	1679# 4X4	\$185.00 a bale/	\$220.40 /a ton
Millet	1231# 3X4	\$125.00 a bale/	\$203.00 /a ton
Millet	1240# 3X4	\$125.00 a bale/	\$201.60 /a ton
Millet	1211# 3X4	\$115.00 a bale/	\$190.00 /a ton
Cornstalks	763# 3X4	\$100.00 a bale/	\$262.20 /a ton
Cornstalks	1128# 3X4	\$125.00 a bale/	\$221.60 /a ton
Cornstalks	1124# 3X4	\$120.00 a bale/	\$213.60 /a ton
Cornstalks	1084# 3X4	\$110.00 a bale/	\$203.00 /a ton
Cornstalks	1095# 3X4	\$110.00 a bale/	\$201.00 /a ton
Praire Hay	1243# ROUND	\$200.00 a bale/	\$321.80 /a ton
Praire Hay	1295# ROUND	\$175.00 a bale/	\$270.20 /a ton
Oats	600# 3X3	\$95.00 a bale/	\$316.60 /a ton
Oats	1723# ROUND	\$225.00 a bale/	\$261.20 /a ton
Milo Stalks	683# 3X4	\$72.50 a bale/	\$212.20 /a ton
Milo Stalks	760# 3X4	\$65.00 a bale/	\$171.00 /a ton
Milo Stalks	712# 3X4	\$52.50 a bale/	\$147.40 /a ton
Sorghum/Grass/Misc Mix	1442# 3X4	\$155.00 a bale/	\$215.00 /a ton

Hot Topics: None

District 4 Update
Sam Montoya
August 27, 2026

Program Updates:

- **2026 Acreage reporting** – All District 4 offices that request an acreage reporting register have completed their registers.
- **2026 NAP** – County offices continue to process NOL and application for payment related to the ongoing drought. Many crops are not expected to be harvested, and offices are preparing appraisal packets and coordination appraisals with loss adjusters.
- **ELAP** – County offices continue to see increased activity under ELAP for livestock water hauling and feed transportation due to drought conditions. Producers are contacting offices for information and submitting notice of loss.
- **LDP** – County offices are processing wool LDP requests and assisting producer with the required application and supporting documentation.
- **LFP** – County offices continue to accept and process LFP applications for eligible livestock producers affected by drought. Staff are reviewing grazing information, livestock inventories, and supporting documentation as applications are received.
- **ECP** – Several District 4 counties are preparing request to implement ECP in response to damage caused by recent fire activity. County offices are gathering information regarding the extent of the damage and identifying the conservation practices that may be needed.
- **Payment Eligibility** – County offices are working to notify and complete payment eligibility determinations for Qualified Pass-Through entities.

Staffing Updates:

- Adrian was selected for the Mesa/Garfield CED position but declined the offer. She subsequently submitted her resignation, her last day with FSA was August 21. Sam Hyslop, the alternate selection, accepted the CED position and began on Monday, August 24.

Crop Conditions, Livestock, and Weather:

- **Western Slope** – Limited irrigation water continues to affect forage crops, corn, pastures, and rangeland. April freeze caused significant fruit losses. The Western Slope and San Luis Valley have received scattered rainfall over the past month. While the moisture has provided temporary relief, it has been inconsistent and has not improved the ongoing drought conditions.
- **San Luis Valley** – Potatoes and small grains are progressing toward maturity, with harvest beginning in some areas. Hay production and overall crop conditions vary depending on irrigation availability. Drought conditions and limited water supplies remain a concern as producers move into the final portion of the growing season.

Acting Farm Loan Chief's Update

Kim Lacy
August 27, 2026

Colorado Loan Data:

Loan Portfolio: Total loans obligated in FY 2026 (10/1/2025 to 08/07/2026) by service center.

Servicing Office	Direct Loans Obligated	Dollars Obligated	Guaranteed Loans Obligated	Dollars Obligated
Alamosa	20	\$3,026,170.00	2	\$795,000.00
Prowers	30	\$4,448,200.00	2	\$850,000.00
Pueblo	20	\$5,349,360.00	3	\$1,833,551.00
Adams	16	\$1,862,000.00	1	\$1,015,000.00
Lincoln	17	\$1,701,030.00	0	\$0
Logan	24	\$5,446,020.00	23	\$10,012,288.00
Mesa	13	\$573,900.00	1	\$275,000.00
Montezuma	11	\$2,207,050.00	0	\$0
Total	154	\$24,613,730.00	32	\$14,780,839.00

Hot Topics:

- August is typically slower time of year for volume of new applications.
- For Direct loans, the number of loans and total amount obligated is still down compared to this time in 2025. Total number of guaranteed loans approved and amount obligated has now exceeded the 2025 numbers at this point in the year.
- Between direct and guaranteed loans combined, there was increase of \$3,767,985 in funds approved over the last 30 days in Colorado.
- Loan funding for 2026 is expected to be adequate for the anticipated loan needs.
- National & State Training: Anticipate a national meeting for Guaranteed Loan Program Modernization Training in mid-September. Following the national training, the program topics will be immediate priority for in person state-level follow-up training as it is required that this training be completed before the end of September to align with the expected publication timeline of the rule.
- Special Servicing: There are options for loan customers during financial stress. If a borrower is unable to make payments on a loan, recommend they contact the local FSA Farm Loan Manager to learn about options.
- FLP Training Updates: No significant changes/updates.
- Vacancies: FLC, Sterling FLOT, Sterling PT/LA, Pueblo PT/LA, Alamosa PT/LA

Farm Program Chief's Update
Cindy Vukasin
August 27, 2026

Upcoming Announcements:

Program Updates: As of Friday, August 21, 2026

- **FBA:** 6,921 payments issued = \$147,881,594; 2 to be disbursed \$6,277 =
Total \$147,887,871
- **ASCF: 522** payments issued = \$11,261,475; 14 to be disbursed \$106,193 =
Total \$11,367,67
Enrollment closed August 7, 2026
- **NAP**
 - PY – 2026:
 - 2,607 Applications for coverage approved (AFC) additional 39 in process (signed by producer or pending). PY 2025 – 2,516 AFC approved.
 - 134 Application for Payment filed (AFP) 20 Approved
 - 17 payments issued = \$105,449; 4 to be disbursed \$220,401 =
Total \$327,850
 - PY 2025 payments disbursed: \$3,998,427
- **LFP**
 - PY 2025: 1,117 Applications approved; Payments disbursed: \$14,644, 657
 - PY 2026: 952 payments issued = \$8,065,673; 53 to be disbursed \$317,436 – **Total \$8,382,809**
 - PY 2026 Counties and crops that have triggered since Junes report:
- **ARC/PLC Data**
 - <https://www.fsa.usda.gov/resources/programs/arc-plc/program-data>
(include pricing and crop lists)
- **2026 Acreage Reporting – State Summary**

Farms with an ACTIVE Acreage Report	Farms Fully Reported PY26	Farms Fully Reported PY25	Percent of Fully Reported Acreage Reports	Crop Records Reported PY26	Crop Records Reported PY25	Percent of Crops Reported
30,455	28,047	29,651	94.59%	220,859	221,300	99.80%

**Farm Program Chief's Update
Corey Pelton
August 27, 2026**

Program Updates:

General:

Farm program specialist attended a national training in Oklahoma City, the week of August 10. This training was focused on the updates made to programs from the Working Families Tax Cut Act. In addition, there was some good overall training with regards to the programs affected. Cindy and I were also able to attend specific sessions virtually. We are now in the process of scheduling in-person training for our county office staff.

Conservation:

County offices and NRCS are still working towards getting conservation planning completed for all 2026 CRP sign-ups.

Conservation payments are expected to be issued early in October.

SDRP

The deadline to apply for all SDRP stages has been extended to September 30, 2026.

**Deputy State Executive Director
Jon Weishaar
August 27, 2026**

Staffing & Hiring

We advertised and hired the CED positions (expanded authority) in Mesa and Weld. Sam Hyslop was hired in Mesa and Dylan Bell was hired in Weld.

We are currently advertising CED positions (expanded authority) in Sedgwick and Phillips. Those advertisements will close on 8/28/2026. After they close, we'll have a panel of Subject Matter Experts review and rank the applications and the top ranked applicants will go to STC for certification. This will be the same process that we used for Mesa and Weld where we'll do an action-between meetings using email.

We are actively trying to advertise an AO position. This advertisement is being held up by the Farm Production and Conservation (FPAC) Business Center (BC) as they are reviewing the position description. The FPAC-BC recently took over the hiring of our GS personnel.

We are also working to fill the various temporary PA positions around Colorado. These positions are now funded through 12/31/2026.

The Deputy Administrator for Field Operations (DAFO) provided each State with new ceiling numbers on 8/19/2026. Colorado's new CO ceiling number is 93 and our new GS ceiling number is 33. The DAFO has also authorized flexibilities for hiring which will allow us to advertise sooner. Jerry and I will be meeting with the DDs to formulate a hiring plan with these extra positions.

Budget

We are planning two major trainings in September: one for the Farm Program staff and one for the Farm Loan staff. The Farm Program training was not initially planned for this fiscal year, so in an effort to reduce disruptions in the service centers, we've decided to pause regional trainings for now.

The Farm Program training is being fully funded by DC, which will help relieve pressure on our state travel budget.

As we approach the end of the fiscal year, we'll continue to monitor our budget closely. We typically reserve larger line-item expenditures for the final quarter to ensure we're not overextended too early in the year. This approach provides flexibility as needs arise and helps us balance travel, training, and operational priorities through the closeout period.

Special Projects

Over the past month, a substantial portion of my time has been devoted to administrative responsibilities. Much of my day-to-day work has involved preparing and processing personnel actions and managing various HR-related functions. As I've become more comfortable with the administrative systems, I've been able to keep pace with the workload more effectively. Once we onboard and train a new AO, I'll be able to transition away from many of these duties and refocus more fully on my core DSED responsibilities.

At the end of August, I will be traveling to Washington, DC with the Workforce Engagement Committee. We will be meeting with agency leadership to discuss opportunities to improve workforce engagement and strengthen connections across the organization. I am optimistic that these discussions will help inform initiatives that support both Colorado and the broader agency.

Looking ahead, one of my key priorities will be the training strategy for the new CEDs we're hiring. Because these positions come with expanded authority, it's essential that we provide structured onboarding, clear expectations, and ongoing support to ensure they have the tools they need to succeed.

In addition, the two statewide trainings scheduled for September will require significant coordination and preparation, alongside the usual end-of-year tasks. September is shaping up to be a busy month as we balance training, personnel needs, and fiscal-year closeout activities.

Regular Session

Noninsured Crop Disaster Assistance Program (NAP)

Delegations of Authority to DD as STC Representative

COLORADO FSA STATE COMMITTEE POLICY

SUBJECT: **STC REPRESENTATIVES**

POLICY: The State Committee can designate the District Directors as their representative/designee in order to approve or disapprove all CCC-576's (notice of loss and application for payment). 1-NAP (Rev. 2) subparagraph 4A requires that all NAP CCC-576: notice of loss and applications executed by FSA employee, including State Office employees, STC members, COC members, CED's, County Office employees, and their spouses to be sent to STC, or designee for action.

District Director (DD) are delegated authority to act on behalf of the STC on applications executed by STC members, COC members, CED's, County Office employees and their spouses.

All applications executed by State Office employees and their spouses will continue to be sent to STC for approval/disapproval. DD's are not delegated authority to act on these applications.

STATE OFFICE DIVISION:	<u>DISASTER</u>
REFERENCE:	<u>1-NAP SUBPAR. 4A</u>
DATE ESTABLISHED:	<u>August 27, 2026</u>
RECORDED IN STC MINUTES:	<u>August 27, 2026</u>
REAFFIRMED AT STC MEETING:	<u></u>

3 DAFP Responsibilities

A Policy and Regulations

DAFP will:

- develop all NAP regulations and policy
- ensure that NAP is administered according to NAP regulations.

4 STC Responsibilities

A Administering Provisions

STC will:

- determine Statewide policy according to this handbook
- administer all phases of NAP in the State through SED
- take any action **required** by either regulation or procedure that COC has **not** taken
- correct, or require COC to correct, any action that is **not** according to NAP regulations or procedure
- require COC to withhold taking any action that is **not** according to NAP regulations or procedure
- ***--require all CCC-576's (notice of loss and application for payment) executed by an FSA employee, including State Office employees, STC members, COC members, CED's, and County Office employees and their spouses, to be sent to STC or designee for action--***
- thoroughly document, in the STC minutes, all program recommendations, such as crop data, program and eligibility determinations, appeals, etc.
- ensure that County Offices accept CCC-471's from producers according to paragraph 301.

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Regular Session

Emergency Forest Restoration Program (EFRP)

CSFS EFRP Implementation Recommendation

State Committee Discussion Record

Program: Emergency Forest Restoration Program

Date: 08/27/2026

Staff Member Presenting:

Hunter A. Cleveland

Action Requested:

Review the recommendation letter submitted from Colorado State Forest Service regarding the implementation of the Emergency Forest Restoration Program (EFRP) in response to the Mountain Pine Beetle Infestation and determine if EFRP implementation is needed.

STC Recommended Action:

It is recommended that the Colorado STC request EFRP implementation as described below for the following counties:

Physical County Office:	EFRP Practices	Signup Duration	Estimated Signup Date	Estimated Funds Needed
Larimer	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000
Boulder	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000
Gilpin	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000
Clear Creek	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000

Jefferson	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000
Douglas	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000
Park	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000
Teller	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000
El Paso	EF2-Softwood Forest Restoration EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures	60 Days	October 1 st - November 30 th	\$1,000,000

Background:

On July 28, 2026, the Colorado State Executive Director received a letter from CSFS recommending implementation of EFRP in the following counties in response to a Mountain Pine Beetle infestation that is currently affecting Colorado:

Physical County Office:
Larimer
Boulder
Gilpin
Clear Creek
Jefferson
Douglas
Park
Teller
El Paso

The attached letter submitted by CSFS provides a detailed technical opinion and damage assessment of the Mountain Pine Beetle infestation.

Based off of this technical opinion, CSFS is recommending implementation of the following EFRP practices in the above listed counties:

EFRP Practices:
EF2- Softwood Forest Restoration
EF3- Mixed Conifer Restoration
EF9- Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures

The Colorado STC will review this recommendation and determine if EFRP implementation is needed in those above-mentioned counties.

Handbook 1-EFRP (Rev. 1) paragraph 2B outlines that EFRP can be implemented in response to a qualifying natural disaster when the Non-Industrial Private Forestland (NIPF) damage is of a magnitude too costly to rehabilitate without federal assistance.

Handbook 1-EFRP (Rev. 1) paragraph 2B does not list insect infestation as an eligible disaster event for EFRP, however, the National Office has verified that insect infestation is an eligible disaster event and that EFRP can be implemented in response to this disaster event. The handbook is pending a revision to include this change.

The EFRP signup implementation request would be submitted with the following information as required by Handbook 1-EFRP (Rev. 1) paragraph 91A:

Date of Disaster	It is difficult to pinpoint an exact disaster start date. CSFS provided the following information: <i>The 2024 Forest Health Report and shows an annual increase of MPB populations statewide starting around 2021.</i>
Type	Insect Infestation
Description	(Refer to CSFS recommendation letter)
Estimated Affected Acres	Measuring the actual acres affected is difficult as FSA doesn't typically have farms

	created in the software for forestland. CSFS provided the following for affected acres: <i>From the 2025 Forest Health Report (current issue) section on MPB, "Results from surveyed areas in Larimer, Boulder, Gilpin, Jefferson, Clear Creek, Teller, Park, Douglas and El Paso counties show increasing mountain pine beetle populations. Impacted acreage in these counties increased from 2,236 acres in 2024 to 5,544 acres in 2025, equivalent to a 148% increase, or 2.48 times the area observed the prior year. On-the-ground reports from CSFS foresters and forest health staff confirmed these aerial observations."</i>
Estimated Funds Needed	\$1,000,000 per county
Expected Signup Dates	October 1 st - November 30 th
Relevant News Articles	State of CO-Article CU Article CSFS Website



5060 Campus Delivery
Fort Collins, CO 80523-5060
(970) 491-6303

Date: July 27, 2026

To: Colorado State Committee and Colorado State Executive Director Jerry Sonnenberg

From: Matthew McCombs, State Forester, Colorado State Forest Service

Subject: Escalating Mountain Pine Beetle Activity in Ponderosa Pine Forests and Anticipated Emergency Forest Restoration Program Needs

Dear FSA State Office Leadership,

As Colorado's State Forester, I am writing to provide an updated assessment of the rapidly emerging mountain pine beetle (MPB) outbreak in ponderosa pine forests along the Front Range and to highlight conditions that may necessitate activation of the Emergency Forest Restoration Program (EFRP) for affected non-industrial private forest (NIPF) landowners. This assessment reflects findings from recent aerial surveys, drought monitoring, and field observations from CSFS staff and our federal partners.

Current MPB Status and Expected Progression

Recent Colorado State Forest Service and U.S. Forest Service data show that MPB activity is expanding aggressively across many of Colorado's Front Range counties including Larimer, Boulder, Gilpin, Clear Creek, Jefferson, Douglas, Park, Teller, and El Paso Counties, with particularly visible mortality along the I-70 and U.S. 285 corridors. Aerial survey trends confirm that beetle populations have strengthened following persistent warm and dry conditions, with expected continued mortality across the next decade under similar climate patterns.

Additionally, widespread browning of ponderosa pine crowns is now visible in several foothill and mid-elevation forests—an indicator of thousands of newly affected trees. This pattern reflects the recent surge in beetle reproductive success, tied to mild winters and drought-stressed host trees.

Impacts to Non-Industrial Private Forests (NIPF)

Many NIPF ownerships lie directly within outbreak-affected landscapes. Resulting impacts include:

- Loss of mature ponderosa pine and associated value;
- Increased hazard-tree threats near homes, driveways, fence lines, and private infrastructure;
- Reduced long-term forest resilience and regeneration potential.

Drought Conditions Intensifying the Outbreak

As of July 9th, 2026, 98% of the state is now in drought, with portions of the western, central, and Front Range regions experiencing severe to extreme drought conditions. Snowpack levels in several basins rank among the lowest observed historically.

These drought conditions are materially contributing to:

- Weakened tree defenses and reduced resin production;
- Higher overwinter survival of beetle larvae;

Research and monitoring confirm that warm, dry years have enabled beetle populations to exceed historical ecological limits, spreading deeper into ponderosa pine systems along the Front Range.

In addition, Governor Polis has activated a statewide [Drought Task Force](#) in response to the ongoing conditions.

Risks and Conservation Consequences if Not Addressed

Without timely intervention, this outbreak poses serious risks to Colorado's forested landscapes and communities, including:

- Loss of forest cover in ponderosa pine and mixed conifer forest types
- Loss of wildlife habitat and changes to forest structure and species composition;
- Deterioration of recreation assets, scenic quality, and tourism-dependent local economies;
- Heightened slope instability and long-term soil degradation following widespread mortality.
- **Threats to critical watersheds**, with sedimentation, debris flow potential, and reduced canopy protection;

Recent mapping and climate assessments indicate that outbreak affected ponderosa pine stands directly overlap with high-risk wildfire corridors and major foothill communities, further underscoring the need for collaborative mitigation.

Recommended EFRP Appropriate Mitigation Practices

Due to the forest types impacted by the current MPB outbreak, we anticipate the following EFRP practices being critical to the response:

1. EF2 - Softwood Forest Restoration
2. EF3 - Mixed Conifer Restoration
3. EF9 – Other Emergency Forest Restoration Measures

In alignment with the above practices, CSFS recommends the following high-priority actions that would directly support impacted NIPF landowners:

1. **Sanitation harvesting** and removal of infested trees to limit local spread.
2. **Targeted thinning** to reduce stand density, increase vigor, and improve resilience.
3. **Slash treatment**—including chipping, grinding, or pile burning—to suppress beetle brood habitat and reduce hazardous fuels.
4. **Defensible space and fuel-break establishment**, especially in WUI communities.
5. **Hazard tree removal** along private access routes, homes, utilities, and infrastructure.
6. **Post disturbance reforestation**, using drought tolerant, site-appropriate species to initiate long-term recovery.

State level directives, including the Governor’s [Ponderosa Mountain Pine Beetle Task Force](#) initiative and [Drought Task Force](#), strongly emphasize rapid response and priority mitigation near communities and critical infrastructure.

CSFS MPB Resources and Mapping Tools

CSFS provides comprehensive MPB identification and management resources, including an interactive map showing current MPB outbreak locations across Colorado. These materials are available at:

Colorado State Forest Service – Mountain Pine Beetle Resources

<https://csfs.colostate.edu/forest-management/common-forest-insects-diseases/mountain-pine-beetle/>

These tools can support FSA’s evaluation of potential EFRP designations and inform prioritization across impacted counties.

Conclusion and Request for Collaboration

Given the accelerating MPB activity, ongoing drought conditions, and growing need for private landowner assistance, CSFS anticipates increased demand for hazard-tree removal, stand restoration, and reforestation support in multiple counties.

Based upon ongoing coordination with the FSA Colorado State Office and USFS, CSFS is requesting activation of EFRP, and we are positioned to deliver timely, effective support to affected landowners and communities.

Thank you for your ongoing partnership and commitment to safeguarding Colorado's forests and the people who depend on them. My office stands ready to provide briefings, data, or additional analysis at your request.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Matthew M. McCombs", written in a cursive style.

Matthew M. McCombs
State Forester & Director
Colorado State Forest Service



Management Options

Small infestations can be eliminated through quick action, such as the removal of infested trees. Residents should inspect pine trees in the fall after mountain pine beetle adults fly to new host trees. After the beetles infest a tree, the best practice is to remove the tree by the following spring, ensuring infested wood is disposed of properly to avoid spreading the beetles.

Large outbreaks of mountain pine beetles are difficult to control. One of the best ways to mitigate the effects of beetle outbreaks is to manage for overall forest health and resiliency. Thinning overly dense stands of trees to reduce competition and promote tree age and species diversity is the most successful forest management strategy to increase tree vigor.

Strategies for managing mountain pine beetles

- **Removal of infested trees and slash** from thinning or pruning will prevent beetles from emerging and flying to new trees. Continual removal of trees already affected by other insects or diseases, as well as trees in overly dense areas, should be prioritized, as beetles most frequently attack unhealthy trees. Residents should contact their local transfer station or landfill to dispose of infested wood and slash, or search online for local wood drop-off locations or businesses that may utilize the material. **Do not move infested wood unless you intend to drop it off at a secure location as it could spread the beetles.**
- **Solar treatments** can be used to reduce mountain pine beetle populations in small, infested stands. These treatments involve felling infested trees, stacking cut logs off the ground in an area with full sun and covering them with clear plastic. The solar treatment of infested trees creates conditions unsuitable for the survival of the beetle's larvae.

- **Trap trees** serve as traps for recently emerged, adult beetles. After the trap trees become infested with beetles, the trees are removed and destroyed, usually during the fall or winter while all of the beetles are still inside.
- **The use of pheromone packets** containing verbenone, known as semiochemicals, disrupts the attraction of incoming beetles and can be used to reduce attacks on pine trees where no other management options are effective (e.g., in proximity to water or near structures where overspray of preventive insecticides may be undesirable). The effectiveness of verbenone has been much debated in the scientific literature, though recent advances in altered concentrations have proven effective when beetle pressure is low. The Colorado State Forest Service does not manage the distribution of pheromone packets to the general public. Residents should place orders early so manufacturers and distributors have sufficient lead time to produce and deliver products before the start of the typical mountain pine beetle flight season in July. Consult the CSFS Forest Health Team for information on using pheromone applications and tips on selecting a supplier.
- **The use of preventive insecticide sprays** may prove effective in preventing mountain pine beetle infestation. Specific formulations of pyrethroids that are registered and tested for effectiveness are the primary preventive insecticidal sprays used to help reduce the likelihood of attacks on individual trees. The Colorado State Forest Service recommends spraying only high-value trees, such as those near homes, businesses or recreation sites. Follow the label of any chosen product. When hiring a professional to spray trees, residents should ensure the professional is a licensed pesticide applicator through the Colorado Department of Agriculture.

Front Range mountain pine beetle-infested wood disposal

The map below displays locations within nine counties along the Front Range accepting bark beetle-infested wood. Locations are delineated by small loads (pickups and trailers from residents) and large loads (semi-truck loads from contractors) and by private or municipality-owned facilities.

Locations are subject to change availability and restrictions by residency. Please follow up with each entity prior to drop-off for current status.

Do you manage a business or site that can process beetle-infested logs? Join our database by visiting our [Mountain Pine Beetle-Infested Wood-Processing Database Application](#) page.



Mountain Pine Beetle-Infested Wood Drop-Off Locations



Esri | TomTom | Garmin | USGS | FAO | NOAA | EPA | NPS | USFWS

Powered by [Esri](#)

[Mountain Pine Beetle Home](#)

[About Mountain Pine Beetles](#)

[Signs and Symptoms](#)

[Management Options](#)

[Additional Resources](#)



Signs and Symptoms

Know how to identify a pine tree infested with mountain pine beetles

Fall is an ideal time for residents to check for the presence of mountain pine beetles in their pine trees, especially lodgepole, ponderosa and limber pines. Each year, these beetles take flight in late summer to look for new host trees. By fall, enough time has passed to see signs of infestation, but the weather is often warm and dry enough for outdoor walks.

Residents should look for these tell-tale signs and symptoms of mountain pine beetle infestation:

- Popcorn-shaped masses of resin, called pitch tubes, on the trunk that may be brown, pink or white
- Boring dust in bark crevices and on the ground immediately adjacent to the tree's base
- Woodpecker damage, where the birds have stripped portions of the bark in search of larvae, leaving accumulations of bark at the base of the tree
- Presence of live mountain pine beetles (eggs, larvae, pupae and/or adults)
- Exit holes on the bark's surface where adult beetles have emerged
- Foliage turning yellowish to reddish throughout the entire tree crown, which usually occurs eight to 10 months after a successful attack



Popcorn-shaped masses of resin, called “pitch tubes,” are found on the trunk where bark has been removed. They can be brown, pink or white. Photo: Dan West, CSFS

[Mountain Pine Beetle Home](#)

[About Mountain Pine Beetles](#)

[Signs and Symptoms](#)

[Management Options](#)

[Additional Resources](#)



About Mountain Pine Beetles

Mountain pine beetles complete a generation within one year from egg to adult. Adults typically fly to seek new host trees in July through August, though a small proportion of adults emerge earlier and some later through the summer months. Attacking females initially prefer large-diameter trees until they are depleted from the forest. However, they may attack smaller-diameter trees during an outbreak as populations explode and fewer host trees are available.

Mountain pine beetles predominantly infest ponderosa pine (*Pinus ponderosa*), lodgepole pine (*P. contorta*) and limber pine (*P. flexilis*). However, numerous species of pines – and all pines found in Colorado except for piñon pine – are susceptible to attack when mountain pine beetle populations explode, including ornamental pines.

Outbreaks in Colorado

The Colorado State Forest Service monitors the spread of mountain pine beetle outbreaks in Colorado through aerial surveys and on-the-ground reports.

Updated July 2026: Ponderosa pine forests in portions of Larimer, Gilpin, Clear Creek, Boulder, Jefferson, Park, Douglas, El Paso and Teller counties are experiencing elevated levels of mountain pine beetle activity. In addition, lodgepole pine forests in Park, Lake and Gunnison counties that largely escaped previous bark beetle outbreaks are now experiencing increased tree mortality as mountain pine beetle populations expand.

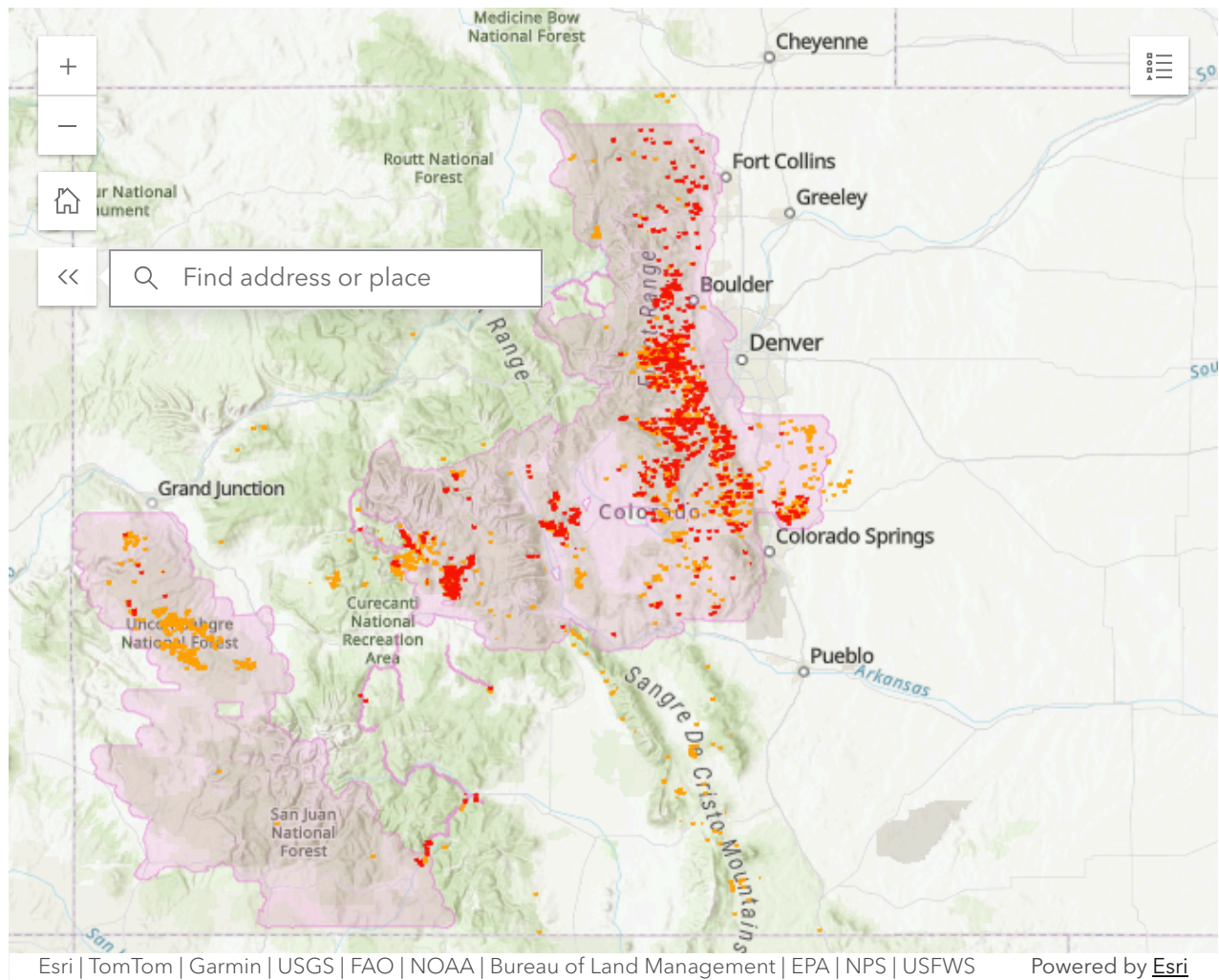
CSFS Forest Health staff continue to monitor adult flight activity along the Front Range. Flights typically begin in early July on the Front Range, according to [trapping data from prior years](#). Based on preliminary trapping data from this year, the emergence timing of adult mountain pine beetles from trees has been variable

among locations, as expected based on observations of larval development. At some sites, traps consistently began collecting adults in mid-June, an earlier emergence than previously recorded in those areas. At other sites, CSFS Forest Health staff have yet to record a peak in emergence activity as of the second week of July.

There is no evidence to suggest a second adult flight period will occur or any other significant changes to the mountain pine beetle lifecycle.

Explore where aerial observers detected mountain pine beetle activity in Colorado's forests over the past four years. This map shows data from an annual aerial survey conducted by the Colorado State Forest Service and U.S. Forest Service. The pink area depicts acreage surveyed from the air in 2025.

Mountain Pine Beetle 2022-2025: Colorado

[Mountain Pine Beetle Home](#)[About Mountain Pine Beetles](#)[Signs and Symptoms](#)[Management Options](#)[Additional Resources](#)



COLORADO

Department of Natural Resources

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Governor Polis Shares Information on Pine Beetle Outbreak, Announces New Task Force to Help Communities, Forests, and Water Resources

Governor Polis Shares Information on Pine Beetle Outbreak, Announces New Task Force to Help Communities, Forests, and Water Resources

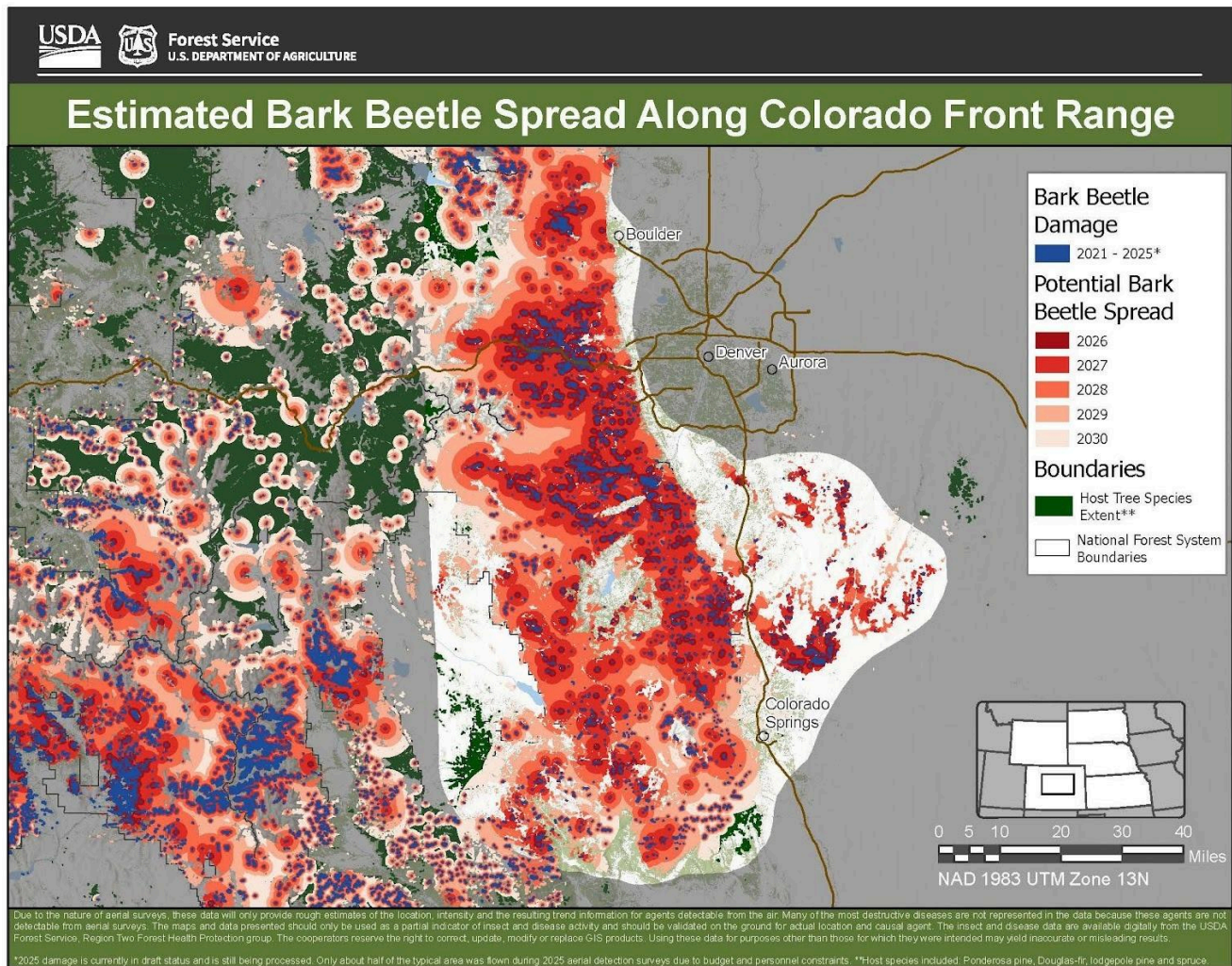
Monday, December 15, 2025

(Evergreen) – Today, Governor Jared Polis, joined by forestry experts, local leaders, and partners across key sectors, shared information on the major pine beetle outbreak taking hold in the Front Range and took [Executive Action](#) in announcing the creation of a new task force designed to protect Colorado forests and communities from the impact the mountain pine beetle will have, particularly on Colorado's Front Range ponderosa forests, over the next decade. The task force created by this action will develop strategies to help protect Colorado communities, critical water resources and forests, support Colorado's outdoor recreation economy, and enhance fire mitigation and response efforts. In addition to the task force, the Governor will seek to extend and boost key wildfire mitigation and beetle kill tax incentives, as well as seek funding for critical wildfire mitigation, community outreach, and research needs, and resources to draw larger federal funding streams.

“Colorado has long been a leader in forest health and fire mitigation efforts, and this is no exception. As the latest outbreak of pine beetles begins to take shape along the densely populated Front Range, we are taking an aggressive approach to boost tools and partnerships to help protect our communities, forests, and key water sources, and equipping homeowners with the resources they need to better protect their homes. I am grateful to our local partners, foresters, and leaders across sectors for helping us take action on this issue,” said Governor Polis.

“I’m grateful to Governor Polis for creating the Ponderosa Mountain Pine Beetle Task Force, and as the Ranking Member on the U.S. House Subcommittee on Federal Lands am grateful for the opportunity to work together to save Colorado’s treasured forests. Hotter and drier climates, along with the year-round threat of wildfires, have weakened our trees’ natural defenses – as we are now witnessing across the Front Range – and we must act decisively to manage and ameliorate the impacts of spiking pine beetle populations to improve forest health,” said Congressman Neguse.

“In Colorado, our public lands are core to who we are, and protecting them is critical to our way of life,” said Congresswoman Brittany Pettersen. **“Mountain pine beetles have devastated millions of acres of forest across our state, increasing the risk of wildfires and threatening the health of our forests. I’m glad to see Governor Polis taking action to address this growing threat and protect our forests so future generations can continue to enjoy Colorado’s outdoor spaces for years to come.”**



The task force will be co-chaired by the Executive Director of the Colorado Department of Natural Resources, the Colorado State Forester, and the Director of the Division of Fire Prevention and Control, with a 20-organization membership which will seek to include representation across critical sectors and partners including local governments, utilities, recreation and tourism, insurance, housing, conservation experts, timber and milling sectors, wildfire and emergency management professionals, federal partners, and philanthropy, among others.

“This mountain pine beetle outbreak is emerging in one of the most heavily populated, heavily recreated regions of Colorado. This task force ensures we are coordinating action across agencies, landowners, industries, and communities to respond quickly and prepare for the long-term realities of changed ponderosa pine forests, addressing wildfire risk and watershed impacts facing the Front Range,” said Dan Gibbs, Executive Director of the Colorado Department of Natural Resources.

“We have learned a lot in the past two decades about what to expect from mountain pine beetle outbreaks, and we will apply those lessons to this outbreak in the ponderosa pine. Our commitment is to address the full problem: treating the forests, building resilient communities, and ensuring our fire response is the best in the nation,” said Mike Morgan, Director of the Colorado Division of Fire Prevention and Control.

To complement the work of the task force, the Governor will also submit a supplemental request of recommended actions to the legislature aimed at reducing wildfire risk, supporting landowners and saving them money on risk mitigation investments, and strengthening Colorado's long-term response to the pine beetle outbreak. These proposals include tax incentives to expand the use of beetle-kill timber, enhanced support for homeowners conducting fire mitigation, innovative research on managing the beetle population, expanding collaboration with federal partners through Good Neighbor Authority, and new tools to accelerate forest health work across public and private lands. Further details on these proposals will be included in the Governor's January 2 budget submission and supplemental requests.

Aerial forest health surveys conducted in 2025 by the U.S. Forest Service and Colorado State Forest Service reveal a significant and expanding mountain pine beetle outbreak in ponderosa pine forests up and down the Front Range, with pockets of brown and beetle-killed trees already visible along the U.S. 285 and I-70 corridors. Warmer temperatures, ongoing drought, and the absence of sustained cold periods have weakened trees and created ideal conditions for beetle survival and spread - conditions expected to continue into the next decade.

State officials have emphasized that early action is essential to reducing long-term fire risk and maintaining and improving insurability in the state. Beetle-killed trees create hazards for firefighters, hikers, utility providers, and local infrastructure. As mortality increases, standing dead timber can intensify fire behavior, threaten transportation corridors, and complicate suppression operations. Many of the most vulnerable areas are located near densely populated communities within the Front Range foothills, where fire risk intersects with homes, businesses, and critical public utilities.

"Bark beetle outbreaks are not new to Colorado. We've been here before, and we know what works. This task force will strengthen partnerships and ensure science-based management guides our response in support of communities across the state. This is not a time to panic. It's a time to ramp up and take action to reduce the impacts of this outbreak and ensure we never allow our forests to become this vulnerable ever again," said Matthew McCombs, State Forester and Director of the Colorado State Forest Service.

"The Forest Service is committed to working collaboratively with our partners across Colorado to improve forest health conditions at the landscape level and reduce the impact of expanding mountain pine beetle populations," said Troy Heithecker, regional forester for the U.S. Forest Service's Rocky Mountain Region.

The task force will coordinate across state, local, federal, private, and nonprofit partners to advance urgent and long-term strategies. Its scope includes:

- Improving cross-jurisdictional collaboration to advance innovative and solution-oriented partnerships, and address risks posed by beetle-killed trees and fuel mitigation.
- Developing public education tools for homeowners and communities.
- Evaluating strategies to protect watersheds and utility infrastructure.
- Protecting the region's outdoor recreation and tourism infrastructure and economies.
- Advancing reforestation planning and forest health through species and age diversity.
- Strengthening wildfire detection, suppression, and recovery innovation.
- Assessing timber markets and opportunities to utilize beetle-kill wood.
- Exploring insurance strategies related to shifting fire risk.
- Identifying new funding strategies and implementing relevant federal wildfire recommendations.



CU Boulder Today

The pine beetles are back. Here's why—and what you can do about it

A mountain pine beetle chewing on a tree. (Credit: Colorado State Forest Service)

📅 1/28/2026 • By [Yvaine Ye](#)

Colorado's warm and dry winters have tipped the balance in a long-running ecological tug-of-war.

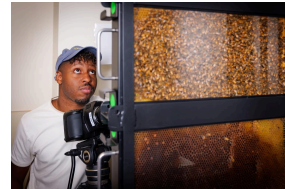
The mountain pine beetles, native insects to the Centennial State, have recently exploded in numbers in the Front Range after a decade of relatively low populations. The mild winter temperatures have allowed more beetle larvae to survive, while the lack of water has weakened pine trees' natural defenses against the bugs.

Already, thousands of pine trees along the U.S. 285 and I-70 corridors are turning brown. The devastation prompted Gov. Jared Polis to [sign](#) an executive order in December to slow the spread of the beetles.

“A very high level of tree mortality, especially among ponderosa pines, is likely to continue for the next decade,” the order [warned](#).

But the insects are not the antagonists of the story, said [Samuel Ramsey](#), assistant professor in the Department of Ecology and Evolutionary Biology and the BioFrontiers Institute.

“They are doing exactly what evolution has primed them to do, and they are just able to do it to the maximum because of the ways that climatic contexts have shifted. That is our fault,” he said.



Samuel Ramsey looking at a beehive in his lab. (Credit: Patrick Campbell/CU Boulder)

The impact extends beyond tree loss. For the Front Range, a densely populated region already under persistent wildfire threat, dead trees can exacerbate risk.

To unpack what’s behind the outbreak and what may come next, CU Boulder Today sat down with Ramsey to chat about its causes, the outlook for Colorado’s forests and steps people can take to limit the damage.

The Mountain pine beetles are native to Colorado. Why are they causing problems now?

As the climate has shifted, it has knocked the beetles out of their normal balance with the trees. Because the weather has been warm for longer stretches of time, these beetles are able to produce an additional generation of babies, in addition to the dozens of offspring they usually produce.

How do the pine beetles attack trees?

The mountain pine beetles are smaller than a grain of rice. When a single pine beetle attacks a tree, it actually can’t do much damage. So, when a pine beetle locates a tree, it will release a smell that tells all the pine beetles in the area to come and attack it. When 1,000 pine beetles all attack the same tree, some



An adult mountain pine beetle. (Credit:

get through and lay eggs in the tree. (Colorado State
Once inside, the beetles will gum up the (Forest Service)
tree's vascular system, cutting off its
water and nutrient supply.

Do trees have a defense mechanism for keeping beetles out?

They did in the original climactic circumstances, such as secreting sap to push out the beetles. But when there isn't enough water, they can only produce a small amount of sap, and that is not enough to fend off thousands of beetles that just keep coming at them.

With the warm weather, pine beetles are also maturing faster. That means the trees are starting their battle against the beetles earlier than they had planned. The trees are also fighting later into the season because of the additional generation of beetles.

How bad will this round of the outbreak be?

I'm not a prognosticator, so I cannot tell you that this is going to be a terrible year. But the data is pointing in the direction. In the past, when we have had the same set of circumstances, we have had a banner year for mountain pine beetles. It is [estimated](#) that out of more than 4 million acres of pine forests across the state, more than 80% were damaged by the beetles between 1996 and 2013.

This winter has been really warm. That means that more pine beetles are going to survive the winter. So starting this year, their population will be large enough to likely overcome the defense of a lot of these trees. We could have dead stands of pine trees just sitting there ready to welcome the next wildfire.

Are mountain pine beetle outbreaks unique to Colorado?

The mountain pine beetles are distributed in many parts of North America, but Colorado kind of has a perfect storm of circumstances. We have these issues with a warmer winter. Really high winds can help these pine beetles move farther distances when they're flying. In

addition, the wind can drive wildfires. Together, those factors make the risks here especially high.

Are there any actions individuals can take to reduce the damage?

There are ways that we can lean into our agency here.

If you have a pine tree in your yard, you need to make sure that it has adequate water by watering it and reducing competition for water from other plants around it.

If you are getting firewood, get it and burn it locally. It's a really, really bad idea to move firewood, because you could inadvertently help spread the beetles.

If you're seeing mountain pine beetles in your area, and you haven't seen that before, contact your local forest service office.

The pheromone packets people used in the past might not be the best solution, because they won't stop an infestation, and sometimes they can make the problem worse by drawing more beetles to an area than would've arrived otherwise.

As the climate continues to warm, these sorts of ecological issues are going to happen more often. So we need to make sure that instead of only treating the symptoms of climate change, we are reducing the amount of carbon that is going into the atmosphere.

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Regular Session

Agriculture Risk Coverage/Price Loss Coverage (ARCPLC)

Missing ARCPLC Yields for Crop Year 2025

State Committee Discussion Record

Program: Agriculture Risk Program and Price Loss Program (ARC/PLC)

Date: 08.27.26

Staff Member Presenting: Doug Andresen, Farm Program Specialist

Matter for Consideration: Review and determine missing ARC-CO yields

Background: The National Office has asked State Committees to update missing yields by county for Crop Year 2025. Crops included are safflower. The information for review can be found in Exhibit 1.

- For ARC-CO the 2025 county yield is computed and used where the farm tract is physically located:
 - ❖ To calculate a current year ARC-CO revenue loss, if applicable.
 - ❖ As the 2025 county benchmark yield to establish ARC-CO benchmark and guarantee revenues.

The 2025 county yields for the 22 covered commodities are used for the ARC-CO and ARC-IC programs and have been compiled using Risk Management Agency (RMA) and National Agricultural Statistics Service (NASS) data when available.

However, there are instances when the 2025 county yields are not available from RMA or NASS. In those instances, State Committee's (STC's) are required to research and establish 2025 yields for the counties missing yield data.

1-ARCPLC policy:

134 Other Yield Information

A STC Calculated Yields where RMA or NASS County Yield Data is Missing or NASS County Yield Data is Not Representative

In certain situations, RMA or NASS county yield data is not available or NASS county yield data does not represent the actual county yield. In order to establish either the benchmark--* yield or actual year yield, STC's must establish a county yield(s) in any year where the yield was not attainable, using the best available information, such as:

- yields from a contiguous county
- NAP yields that were established for the covered commodity
- in cases where STC's cannot find supporting yield data, STC can request the local COC to provide information/documentation at the local level that can be submitted and reviewed by STC
- State or district level NASS data
- State yield data from contiguous States.

Note: Some counties and covered commodities have been designated as both an irrigated and non-irrigated county (HIP). For these counties, STC's are required to provide both irrigated and non-irrigated yields. For other counties and covered commodities, yields are not broken out between irrigated and non-irrigated practices and are designated as "All".

When completing the yield for each covered commodity and year, the State Office **must** provide the county yield (that is 100 percent of the county yield).

134 Other Yield Information

B Missing T-Yields

T-yields are used as the substitute yield for low yields in the benchmark years for ARC-CO and ARC-IC. FSA presently has T-yields that are the weighted T-yields from RMA for covered commodities that were insured in the applicable county in the applicable year. When the covered commodity did **not** have crop insurance in the county in the year in question, the STC will be requested to assign a NAP T-yield that covered commodity in that county.

STC will first assign the NAP T-yield for the covered commodity in that county, as applicable. For counties that have both IR and NI yield data, STC will determine a T-yield for both practices. In cases where STC did **not** determine a NAP T-yield for the covered commodity or county, STC must follow policy in 1-NAP to establish a NAP county-expected T-yield for that covered commodity and county.

T-yields computed according to the policy in 1-NAP and used solely in the ARC and PLC programs are **not** required to be loaded into NCT.

STC's will be contacted by the National Office in any year where a missing yield or T-yield is required to complete the ARC-CO or ARC-IC benchmark and/or actual revenue.

STC assigned yields for calculating payments:

- Year specific yields (2025) will be used to calculate 2025 payments by multiplying the Actual Yield (RMA, NASS, or STC) x the 2025 National Price.

State Name	County Name	Sub Cou	Crop Name	Unit	ARC-CO Yield Designatic	(county yield or 80% of T)	(county yield or 80% of T)	(county yield or 80% of T)	(county yield or 80% of T)	(county yield or 80% of T)
Colorado	Adams		Grain Sorghum	Bushel	All	38.86	21.40	22.05	20.84	30.93
Colorado	Arapahoe		Grain Sorghum	Bushel	All	39.33	16.80	20.93	17.24	33.00
Colorado	Baca		Grain Sorghum	Bushel	Irrigated	85.95	61.40	67.50	68.46	68.75
Colorado	Baca		Grain Sorghum	Bushel	Nonirrigated	44.25	21.35	28.85	21.13	22.62
Colorado	Bent		Grain Sorghum	Bushel	Irrigated	68.99	59.31	77.45	63.58	70.72
Colorado	Bent		Grain Sorghum	Bushel	Nonirrigated	38.30	15.20	37.77	31.00	25.00

2025 Bench Mark (2019-23 olympic a	2025 Bench Mark Price (2019-23 olympic a	2025 Benchmark Revenue	2025 Guarantee Revenue	2025 Maximum Payment Rate	2025 Actual Yield	2025 National Price	2025 Actual Revent	2025 Formula Payment Rate
24.79	\$5.3000	\$131.39	\$113.00	\$13.14				
23.72	\$5.3000	\$125.72	\$108.12	\$12.57				
68.24	\$5.3000	\$361.67	\$311.04	\$36.17				
24.27	\$5.3000	\$128.63	\$110.62	\$12.86				
67.76	\$5.3000	\$359.13	\$308.85	\$35.91				
31.26	\$5.3000	\$165.68	\$142.48	\$16.57				

- The STC is completing 2025 yields, which will be used for the 2025 program year benchmark yield, using yields from 2019-2023
- The yields assigned to each crop, for each county, by the STC will be used as the county yield. Which will then be used to calculate the benchmark yield
- STC will also assign T-yields, if not already established by RMA.
- If needed 80% of the T-yield will be used as a substitute yield
- If the substitute yield is greater than the County Yield, the substitute yield will be used in the benchmark calculation (80% of T-yield)

Grain Sorghum					
Yield <u>1</u> /	90	40	75	80	99
ARC Substitute Yield <u>2</u> /	60	60	60	60	60
MYA Price <u>3</u> /	\$3.22	\$5.02	\$5.99	\$6.33	\$4.25
Reference Price <u>4</u> /	\$3.95	\$3.95	\$3.95	\$3.95	\$3.95

- The benchmark yield is calculated using the Olympic average for the 5 crop years preceding the year prior to the program year.
ie: 2025 program payments will use yields from 2019 – 2023

Action Requested: The State Committee has reviewed the missing yields for each county, along with the applicable policies and supporting documentation, and determined the appropriate yield to be entered. It is recommended that the yields are approved as presented.



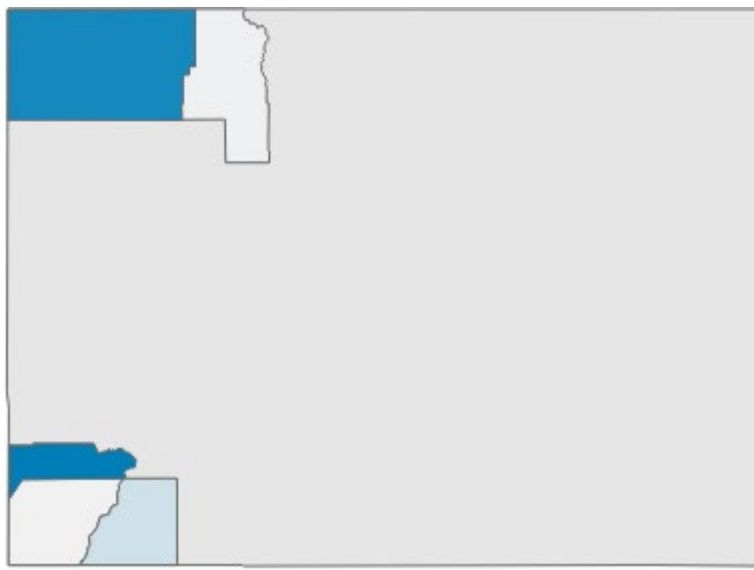
Established RMA Yield - Must Remain	
Yield Recommendation - STC Determined Yield Needed	

2025 Safflower All Actual Yield & Safflower T-Yield

State Name	County Name	Crop Name	Unit	CY 2025 All Actual Yield	CY 2025 All T- Yield	Decision Criteria
Colorado	Arapahoe	SAFFLOWER	Pound	606.75	956.00	Average (San Juan, UT SCO Yield & Colorado NASS Yield) x County percent of State Average Benchmark Yield
Colorado	Dolores	SAFFLOWER	Pound	606.75	956.00	
Colorado	Elbert	SAFFLOWER	Pound	698.92	1,108.43	
Colorado	Kit Carson	SAFFLOWER	Pound	788.97	1,273.00	
Colorado	La Plata	SAFFLOWER	Pound	788.97	1,273.00	
Colorado	Larimer	SAFFLOWER	Pound	788.97	1,273.00	
Colorado	Lincoln	SAFFLOWER	Pound	743.94	1,179.82	
Colorado	Logan	SAFFLOWER	Pound	627.39	956.00	
Colorado	Montezuma	SAFFLOWER	Pound	657.99	956.00	
Colorado	Prowers	SAFFLOWER	Pound	788.97	1,273.00	
Colorado	Routt	SAFFLOWER	Pound	610.50	968.21	
Colorado	San Miguel	SAFFLOWER	Pound	625.25	991.59	
Colorado	Weld	SAFFLOWER	Pound	623.64	989.04	
	Average (CO NASS & San Juan, UT SCO)		689			

Notes:

2025 Safflower planted in Colorado;
8,096.44 acres all non-irrigated
Counties: Moffat, Routt, La Plata, Dolores, Montezuma



Map of Colorado showing 2022 Actual and Target (T-Yield) yields for corn by county. The map is color-coded: yellow for counties with both actual and target yields, and grey for counties with no available data (N/A).

County	Actual Yield (2022)	Target Yield (T-Yield)
Adams	N/A	N/A
Alamosa	N/A	N/A
Arapahoe	606.75	956
Archuleta	N/A	N/A
Baca	N/A	N/A
Bent	N/A	N/A
Boulder	N/A	N/A
Broomfield	N/A	N/A
Chaffee	N/A	N/A
Clear	N/A	N/A
Conejos	N/A	N/A
Costilla	N/A	N/A
Crowley	N/A	N/A
Custer	N/A	N/A
Delta	N/A	N/A
Denver	N/A	N/A
Douglas	N/A	N/A
Dolores	606.75	956
Elbert	698.92	1108.43
El Paso	N/A	N/A
Fremont	N/A	N/A
Garfield	N/A	N/A
Gunnison	N/A	N/A
Hinsdale	N/A	N/A
Huerfano	N/A	N/A
Jefferson	N/A	N/A
Kit Carson	788.97	1273
Kimberly	N/A	N/A
Kiowa	N/A	N/A
Larimer	788.97	1273
Las Animas	N/A	N/A
La Plata	788.97	1273
Lincoln	743.94	1179.82
Logan	627.39	956
Mesa	N/A	N/A
Montezuma	657.99	956
Montrose	N/A	N/A
Morgan	N/A	N/A
Moffat	N/A	N/A
Morongo	N/A	N/A
Ouray	N/A	N/A
Otero	N/A	N/A
Park	N/A	N/A
Pitkin	N/A	N/A
Pueblo	N/A	N/A
Prowers	788.97	1273
Rio Grande	N/A	N/A
Rio Blanco	N/A	N/A
Rio Puerco	N/A	N/A
Routt	610.5	968.21
Saguache	N/A	N/A
San Juan	N/A	N/A
San Miguel	625.25	991.59
Sedgwick	N/A	N/A
Seminole	N/A	N/A
Summit	N/A	N/A
Teller	N/A	N/A
Washington	N/A	N/A
Weld	623.64	989.04
Yuma	N/A	N/A

